

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Pentecost 11
Another Kind of Freedom ~ Healing Division
16 August 2026

LVF updated 9am Tuesday

Preaching: LVF

Worship Leading: ML & Lauren Seely

STRIPS OF PAPER IN PROGRAM FOR PRAYERS

Tech: we will need the piano for the offertory anthem, and one microphone for offertory solo. SOUND CHECK AT 8:45 AM

Organ Prelude-Concert

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Chiming of the Hour

[ML & Lauren center chancel]

Welcome

ML

Words of Gathering

ML & LS

LS: We are inseparable from generations past
and generations future.

The lives of the ones who came before us
are present all around us.

The needs of those to come call upon us this day.

ML: What are we doing with all we have inherited -
the wonderful and the terrible?
What will we leave behind?

Both: *May the Holy things, the righteous things,
the things that make us brave in spirit
and fierce in hope
be our source of wisdom and guidance
as we strive to live faithfully-
to the Sacred
to each other
to those past and yet to come
in these perilous and precious days*

we have been given.

LS: May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

[-enfleshed]

ML: *Please stand, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering*

***Hymn of Gathering**

From Wisdom Emerging

ST. DENIO

 **From Wisdom Emerging (ST. DENIO).pdf**

From Wisdom emerging, we fashion a space
for people converging in safety and grace,
to shelter the freedom of one and of all
in Love without border or boundary or wall.

Faith's journey reclaiming, we blaze a new trail
with others, exclaiming: "Let justice prevail!"
Rejecting worn paths that oppress and mislead,
we walk in community, cherished and freed!

Forever exploring, we seek to learn more
of Wisdom's outpouring, of Love's open door.
Amazed at the mysteries and graces we find,
we joyfully share them with all humankind.

The future progressing, we move through its change,
old systems redressing, new patterns arrange;
protecting all the freedoms with every new choice,
we follow the Spirit and raise our clear voice!

[Michael center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness and Confession**

ML

Let us pray together:

Holy One of freedom and liberation and reconciliation -
you have given us the law, spoken through prophets,
and provided us with the Spirit to help guide us
in love and justice.

Still we struggle.

The complexities of life and challenges of being human
often win over. In our pain we harm one another,
we do not intervene when our neighbors are targeted,
and we become possessive of power and resources.

Forgive us, O God.

And then, Gracious One,
ground our lives in mutual care and connection,
as we share with you - a vision of the belovedness
of each one of us, which is always and forever -
the cornerstone of your collective reality.

***For this and so much more, we are grateful.
Amen and Amen!***

[adpt/enfleshed]

***Introit**

Let All the World in Every Corner Sing

Ralph Vaughan Williams

Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*; Dr. Emma Whitten, *Organ*

[Lauren to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

LS

Let us join together in this Lord's Prayer, adapted by enfleshed...

*Mother of us all,
who dwells within and beyond,
Sacred is your name.
May your holy vision for collective flourishing
come to fruition among us.
May your dreams of justice, love, compassion,
and connection be enfleshed on earth.
Provide us today with what we need to be nourishedd
in body, soul, and heart.
Forgive us for the harm we cause as we seek to
forgive those who have harmed us.
Lead us away from everything that destroys
and liberate us from the hands of evil.
For you are the ultimate source of hope.
Your power-with exceeds all power over.
Your presence incites eternal wonder.
All praise to you, our comfort and strength.
Amen and Amen!*

[-enfleshed]

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Michael center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

ML

In the center of the whirlwind
lies an eye.
Still.
Open.
Calm.
Before we come into the world,
it is as though we live in that center –
no worries,
no storms,
only peace.

As we find our way in life,
even in the midst of chaos,
may we remember that center
and, as the need arises,
and it must,
may we hold
to the calm, open, stillness,
knowing it as home. [gvosper]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you.

Please be seated

[Lauren to lectern]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from the Gospel of Luke*
Hear now this reading from the Gospel of Luke, chapter 9...

LS

As the time approached when he was to be taken from this world, Jesus firmly resolved to proceed toward Jerusalem and sent messengers on ahead. They entered a Samaritan town to make preparations for him, but the Samaritans wouldn't welcome Jesus because his destination was Jerusalem. When the disciples James and John saw this, they said, "Rabbi, do you want us to call down fire from heaven and destroy them?" But Jesus turned and reprimanded them. Then they set off for another town.

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

[Emma short transition Michael to center chancel]

Prayers with the People

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

[After 2 minutes, Emma transition out of silence and play as people come forward to offer prayers and light candles]

Prayer of Our Hearts

Gracious and Holy One,
we gather this morning
opening to your healing power.
We do not understand all the things
that make us whole,
nor the mystery of all that hurts us in body,
mind, and spirit.

But we do know this:
that the presence of the Christ,
the hidden wholeness coursing
through your wondrous universe,
weaves, from the dropped threads of unfinished lives,
a fabric of unmatched beauty.
We come this morning, O God,
seeking less to understand this Healing Source
than to open ourselves
to its sacred flow,
released in us
through this simple act of gathering -
singing, praying, and holding one another and our
beautiful, but often broken world -
in your love.

This we pray.

Amen. [adapt/bsanguin]

[Emma transition small ensemble to positions]

Meditation Anthem *That Which Can't be Explained* Peter Eldridge/Arr. Katelyn Dietz
Katelyn Dietz, Chohi Kim, Frank Hobbs, Kion Heidari, David Conley, *Small Ensemble*
Rohan Ramanam, *Soloist*, Katelyn Dietz, *Director*

[Emma transition Laura to pulpit]

Sermon

Healing Division

LVF

[Emma transition Lauren to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

LS

Gardens QR Code

Offertory Anthem

Rondo

John Carter

Brandon Harris, *Soloist*, Dr. Emma Whitten, *Piano*

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Lauren to lectern]

***Offering Prayer**

LS

Let us offer this prayer together:

Holy Mystery,

we pray this morning ---

mindful of all that has brought us together,

of the Spirit of Life at work in our lives,

and of what may be possible

if we allow this Spirit to work

freely in each of us.

Let our generosity increase

as our lives are transformed

so that we may be

light and life in this place.

Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

[Michael and Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church

LVF & ML

ML: Our gardens have acquired two cats to care for the space, lovingly trained by Michael Wickstrom. Last week, our youth named the cats and Ianthe informs us that these brilliant puns come directly from the teens themselves! Please welcome to our community the cats of Amanda Scott Gardens: Bartholomew Simpson the Third, and Meowy Magdalene, middle name Jalene: representing the first initial of each of the youth's first names.

Words of Blessing

LVF

As we leave this sacred time and space,

Let us gather our courage in community, because...

We can do hard things

Brave things

Beautiful things

Risky and transformative things.

The Sacred travels with those who journey toward freedom.

For the sake of the collective life

For the sake of disrupting evil

For the sake of the human soul.

We are called and companioned,
never really alone.

***May our hearts be encouraged both this day -
and in all the days to come.***

[-enfleshed]

Amen and Amen!

Choral Response

Amen

Kelly McCandless

So let it be. So it shall be. Let us love one another. Amen.

*Hymn for the Journey

Come Now, O Wisdom

SLANE

 **Come Now, O Wisdom (SLANE).pdf**

Come now, O Wisdom, we need your clear voice;
Speak and awaken our hearts to rejoice.
Gracious Creator of more than we know,
In your own image may we ever grow.

Come now, O Wisdom, abide in our souls;
Stir in us visions of life free and whole.
Wisdom, your pathway to justice and peace,
With you our dreams find their fullest release.

Wisdom, more precious than rubies or gold;
With you our graces forever unfold.

No fame or fortune with you can compare;
Pour out your blessings, so rich and so rare.

Wisdom your grace joins all heaven and earth;
With you we labor new life to give birth.
Come now, O Wisdom, our Midwife and Friend,
Open our hearts to your world without end.

-lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton

[Michael center chancel]

Postlude

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Inside the Music - Dr. Ianthe Marini

In our musical exploration today of *healing division*, we focus on that which unites us. We begin with the call for unity —*let all the world in every corner sing*— composed by the prominent 20th century British progressive social activist Ralph Vaughan Williams, whose work was informed by his ideals that the healing properties of music should be accessible for all and not reserved for the economic elite. We hear the urgency in his invitation through the insistence of the organ line and the rhythmic pulse of the choral homophony. Sometimes *love* sounds rousing! We meditate on the theme of healing with the tune and poem *That Which Can't be explained* by Peter Eldridge, arranged by Laude's own Katelyn Dietz. In it, the singer inquires about *differences unreconciled*, questions of *shaky refuge*, and the agnostic presence of spirit, connecting always to *loving that which can't be explained*. Sometimes *love* sounds intangible and uncertain!

Brandon and Dr. Whitten then offer us the Rondo from John Carter's Cantata which implores us to *ring-a-them-bells*, referring to the joyful anticipation of the Jesus who came to heal the nations. Sometimes *love* sounds insistent! And finally, we sing *Amen* —*let it be so*— in the Kelly McCandless sonic poem which explores the meaning of the word. In it, she discovers that *Amen*, to her, means *so let it be—so it shall be—we shall be who we are, one in the spirit*. *Let us love one another—Amen*. Sometimes, *love* sounds like radical acceptance and the healing of division.